CUSTOMER SERVICE ESSENTIALS: LEVEL 1

Customer Service Essentials: Level 1 — Day 4: Phone, Chat and Email: Messages That Hold Up

Study guide · Self-study

Day 4: Phone, Chat and Email: Messages That Hold Up

How to Use This Guide

This guide is for you, working alone. There is no class and no group. Read one section, then stop and write. The writing is where the learning happens.

You already know how to open a contact and how to stay steady with an angry customer. Today you add a new skill: making your message hold up in each channel. Phone, chat and email are not the same job wearing different clothes. Each one carries your words differently, and each one fails differently.

Work through the sections in order. Keep a pen and paper beside you, or a blank document. When a section asks you to write, write before you read on. The model answers at the end are examples, not scripts. Your words should sound like you.

Every exercise here works without a job. You can role-play with a friend, record yourself, or observe a real service interaction as a customer and take notes on what you see.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: You will know the three parts of a message that holds up (what you know, what you are doing, when they will hear from you) and the four dials (detail, warmth, speed, words).

Attitude: You will treat each message as something the customer may reread, quote or act on alone, not as words that vanish once spoken.

Skill: You will be able to write a chat message, an email and a case note that another person could act on without calling the customer back.

Upskill: You will be able to adjust the four dials between a frustrated customer and a relaxed one in the same channel, and explain why you turned each dial where you did.

Why the Channel Changes the Job

A customer contacts service with a problem and a feeling. On the phone, your voice carries both. In chat, your speed and brevity carry them. In email, your record carries them. The same sentence can land well in one and badly in another.

The psychology here is simple. People read messages with the two speeds of thinking that Daniel Kahneman described. Fast, automatic thinking handles familiar, easy things. Slow, effortful thinking kicks in when something feels unclear or heavy. A message that is easy to process feels calm and trustworthy. A message that is jumbled, too long or full of gaps forces slow thinking, and slow thinking makes people careful and suspicious.

So the channel decides what your message must protect. On the phone, protect tone. In chat, protect the customer's time. In email, protect the record, because the customer will reread it later, possibly when they are more annoyed than when they first wrote. A sentence that felt fine in the moment can look cold at eleven at night.

One rule sits above every channel: never promise anything that has not been verified. If you are not sure the refund is approved, say what you know and when you will know more. Unverified promises

are the fastest way to lose a customer's trust. Baumeister and colleagues found that bad events tend to weigh more than good events of similar size, so one broken promise can outweigh many kept ones.

Reflect for a moment: think of a service email you have received as a customer and read twice. What made you reread it? Was it clarity, or was it doubt?

The Three-Part Message

Every message that holds up answers three questions: what you know, what you are doing, and when the customer will hear from you. Write them in that order. The order matters, because it follows the customer's own questions.

What you know comes first because the customer's fast thinking is asking "do they understand my problem?" Naming their situation clearly settles that question and lowers the temperature. This is the same principle as labeling a feeling on the phone: Lieberman and colleagues found that putting feelings into words calms the response.

What you are doing comes second. It tells the customer someone owns the issue and something is moving. People tolerate waiting far better when they know a step is underway.

When they will hear from you comes last. It is the part most people skip, and it is the part that prevents the follow-up call. A customer who knows the next contact is coming waits. A customer who does not know calls back, often angrier.

Here is a clumsily written chat message, and a version that holds up.

Clumsy: "Hi, we received your request about the double charge and it has been forwarded to the relevant department. Please wait."

Better: "Hi — I can see the double charge on your account for the monthly plan, taken twice on the same day. I've flagged it to our billing team with your reference. You'll hear from me here with an update before the end of tomorrow."

The better version says what is known, what is being done, and when the next contact comes. It contains no promise about the money itself, because the refund has not been verified yet. That distinction matters, and we return to it below.

Now write your own. Choose a simple fictional problem — a late delivery, a wrong item, a login that stopped working. Write a three-part chat message of three sentences or fewer.

Practice example: A customer named Dana writes: "I was charged twice for the same monthly plan. That's 48 in total when it should be 24." You check and confirm the charge was taken twice. Your chat reply: "Dana, I can see two charges of 24 on the same day for the monthly plan. I'm sending both to billing now so they can review the duplicate. I'll message you here with what they confirm by this time tomorrow." The numbers are fictional and in your local currency.

Why does this work? It gives Dana proof you looked (the amounts), it keeps moving (sent to billing), and it removes the need to chase you (a time).

The Four Dials: Detail, Warmth, Speed and Words

A message has four dials you can turn: how much detail you give, how much warmth you show, how fast you respond, and how many words you use. Matching the dials to the customer is the skill of the day.

Detail. A relaxed customer with a complex question wants more detail. A frustrated customer wants less: one clear sentence about what happens next beats a paragraph of explanation. Too much detail reads as evasion to an angry person.

Warmth. Warmth is not friendliness for its own sake. It signals that you see the person, not just the case. A short "I can see why that's frustrating" raises warmth. On email, warmth often lives in the first and last line. In chat, it lives in one human sentence before the facts.

Speed. Chat rewards fast first replies. Phone rewards a calm, unhurried pace. Email rewards a considered reply, but not a slow one: a quick acknowledgment that the full answer is coming beats a perfect answer three days later.

Words. Fewer words, simpler words. Short sentences. One idea per sentence. Customers under stress process less, not more, so plain language lands where clever language bounces off.

How you set the dials depends on what the customer brings. A frustrated customer needs lower detail, higher warmth, fast first reply and fewer words. A relaxed customer with a complicated request can take higher detail and can wait a little longer for a fuller answer.

Practice example: A relaxed customer writes a long email asking how to change the delivery address on an existing order and whether the change costs anything. You reply with four short numbered steps for the change, a plain line saying whether a fee applies based on what you verified in the system, and one sentence inviting them back if any step fails. Detail high, warmth moderate, speed normal, words moderate. Had this customer opened with "This is the third time I've asked," you would lower detail, raise warmth and cut words.

Now write two short chat replies to the same fictional problem — one for a frustrated customer, one for a relaxed one. Then write one sentence for each explaining which dial you turned and why.

A caution: warmth is not apology. A scripted apology with no action behind it reads as empty, and today's dials cannot rescue it.

Messages That Hold Up: Email and Case Notes

Email is a record. The customer will reread it, maybe forward it to a colleague, maybe quote it back to you weeks later. This changes how you write. On chat, a small ambiguity can be cleared in one more line. In email, an ambiguity becomes a dispute.

An email that holds up does four things. It names the problem in the customer's own terms. It states the facts you have verified, and separates them from what you still do not know. It gives the three-part message. It ends with a clear next step and a date, phrased as a real choice or a how or what question, never a yes/no question. Chris Voss calls these how and what questions calibrated questions. "What would be the best number to reach you on Thursday if billing needs to confirm

anything?" works. "Shall I call you?" does not, because it invites a flat no and gives the customer nothing to decide.

The same discipline applies to case notes. A case note is a message to whoever picks up the case next — possibly you tomorrow, possibly someone else. If they have to call the customer back to understand the case, the note has failed.

A case note that works has three lines:

☐ Facts: what the customer reported, with dates, amounts and references as given.

☐ What was promised: exactly what the customer was told, in the words used, including any date.

☐ What is verified: what you checked and confirmed, and what is still open.

Practice example: A case note reads "Customer called about refund. Handled." That note helps nobody. A note that works says: "Customer (Kai, ref 2214) reports a duplicate charge of 36 on the annual plan, charged twice on the 3rd. Told Kai billing will confirm within two working days. Verified: both charges present in the system. Open: refund not yet approved."

Now write a case note for the Dana example earlier, using the three lines above. Write it as if a stranger will read it with no access to you.

Personal data needs care in every channel. Share only what the next person needs to act. Do not repeat card numbers, full addresses or identity details that are not needed for the case. When you are unsure whether something is safe to include, leave it out and point to where the verified record lives.

> **NOTES**
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> Watch for the common mistake of promising a refund before it is approved. Write "billing will confirm" rather than "you will be refunded."

What Would You Say?

Write your answer to each situation before reading the model answers. Your words should sound like you.

1. A customer in chat writes: "My order was supposed to arrive Monday and it's Thursday." You can see the parcel is delayed but not why. Write a three-part chat reply.

2. The same customer replies: "That's what you said on Monday." Set the four dials and write your next chat message.

3. A customer emails: "I want to cancel my subscription and I want a refund for last month. This is the second request." Write the opening two lines of your email.

4. You must hand an unresolved case to someone else. Write the three-line case note for a customer whose delivery was delayed and who was told to expect an update by Friday.

5. Rewrite this email line so it holds up: "Your complaint has been escalated and we will get back to you as soon as possible."

Key Takeaways

- Each channel carries your message differently: the phone carries tone, chat carries speed, email carries a record the customer will reread.
- A message that holds up has three parts: what you know, what you are doing, when they will hear from you.
- The four dials are detail, warmth, speed and words. Turn them to match the customer: frustrated gets less detail, more warmth, faster reply and fewer words.
- Never promise what has not been verified. Say what you know and when you will know more.
- A case note another person can act on has facts, what was promised, and what is verified.
- Share only the personal data the next person needs, and leave out the rest.
- End email and chat with a how or what question or a real choice with a date, never a yes/no question.

Quiz

Answer the five questions. Write your answer before checking the notes.

1. Which part of a three-part message tells the customer when they will hear from you?

   A. The part where you name what you know
   B. The part where you explain what you are doing
   C. The part where you give the next contact time
   D. The part where you thank them for waiting

2. A frustrated customer has just written "third time I've asked." Which dial setting fits best?

   A. High detail, low warmth, slow reply, many words
   B. Low detail, high warmth, fast reply, few words
   C. High detail, high warmth, slow reply, many words
   D. Low detail, low warmth, fast reply, many words

3. The refund has not yet been approved. What should your email say?

   A. "You will be refunded within five days."
   B. "The refund has been approved and will arrive soon."
   C. "Billing will confirm within two working days and I will write to you then."
   D. "Refunds are handled by another team I cannot contact."

4. A case note that another person can act on contains which three things?

   A. Facts, what was promised, what is verified
   B. Customer name, your name, your shift
   C. Problem, apology, closing line
   D. Summary, opinion, recommendation

5. Which ending belongs in an email that holds up?

   A. "Shall I call you tomorrow?"

   B. "Would you like a refund?"

   C. "Can I close this case?"

   D. "What time on Thursday would suit you for a call?"

Upskill Challenge

Over the next two days, build a small channel file of your own and use it once out loud.

Pick three fictional customer problems, one for each channel. For each, write the message in the three-part form. For the chat one, set the four dials for a frustrated customer and write a sentence explaining each dial. For the email one, end with a how or what question or a real choice with a date.

Then write one case note for one of the problems, using the three lines. Check it by reading it as a stranger: could you act on it without calling the customer back?

Finally, rewrite one clumsy model message from this guide in your own words and read it aloud. Record it on your phone or say it to a friend. Listen for whether it sounds like you, and whether the next contact time is clear. Adjust and read it once more.

> **NOTES**
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> Reading your message aloud catches what looks fine but sounds cold or vague. Keep the structure; change the words until they sound like yours.

Model Answers

1. Chat reply for a late order (three parts): "Hi — I can see your order was due Monday and it's still not with you. I'm checking with the delivery team now on where the parcel is. I'll message you here with what they tell me by the end of today." What you know, what you are doing, when they will hear. No promise about the parcel itself.

2. Next chat message after "That's what you said on Monday": dial up warmth and speed, dial down detail and words. "You're right, and I'm sorry it's gone past what you were told. I'm chasing it now and I'll come back to you within the hour with a real answer or a firm date." One human line, one action, one time.

3. Email opening for a cancellation and refund request: "Thank you for writing, and I can see this is your second request, so I'll keep it simple. I've logged your cancellation and I'm checking what can be refunded for last month; I'll write to you by Thursday with exactly what is confirmed." It names the frustration, states the verified step and gives a date — without promising a refund that is not yet approved.

4. Case note for the delayed delivery: "Facts: Customer (ref 4481) reports a delivery due Monday that has not arrived by Thursday. Promised: update on the parcel by Friday. Verified: the parcel is delayed in transit; the cause is not confirmed. Open: new delivery date not set." A stranger could act on this without calling the customer.

5. Rewrite of "escalated and we will get back to you as soon as possible": "I've sent your case to the team that handles this, and I'll write to you by Wednesday with an update." It replaces "as soon as possible," which is not a time, with a date.

- Quiz answers:
- 1. C. The third part gives the next contact time, which is the part most people skip and the part that prevents the chase call.
- 2. B. A frustrated customer needs fewer words, more warmth and a fast first reply; high detail reads as evasion to someone who is angry.
- 3. C. Never promise what has not been verified; state what is known, what is happening and when they will hear more.
- 4. A. Facts, the exact promise made and what is verified let the next person act without calling the customer back.
- 5. D. It is a real choice with a date; options A, B and C are yes/no questions that invite a flat no.

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